WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital

SINGAPORE

Asia East

Information current as of October 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

office@lordwaverley.com
www.lordwaverley.com

WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Central Business District / Marina Bay	Asia's leading financial and regional headquarters hub, home to global banks, asset managers and multinational regional offices	Financial services, wealth management, regional headquarters, professional services
Tuas / western industrial belt	Site of the new automated Tuas mega-port and advanced manufacturing estates, supporting a port that handled a record 44.66 million TEUs in 2025	Port logistics, advanced manufacturing, semiconductors, maritime services
Jurong Island	Integrated energy and chemicals hub and a focus for low-carbon fuels and specialty chemicals	Energy, specialty chemicals, sustainable materials, alternative marine fuels
one-north	R&D and innovation district for biomedical, digital and deep-tech firms, where Budget 2026 is expanding a dedicated AI park	Artificial intelligence, biomedical sciences, research and development
Changi / Seletar	Global aviation hub and aerospace cluster serving regional connectivity and maintenance, repair and overhaul (MRO)	Aviation, aerospace MRO, air logistics
Woodlands (north)	Gateway to Johor and the Johor-Singapore Special Economic Zone, with the RTS Link to Johor Bahru targeted to open by end-2026	Cross-border manufacturing, logistics, business services
Johor-Singapore Special Economic Zone (JS-SEZ)	Joint zone allowing investors to pair Singapore headquarters and finance with Johor land and labour; Singapore-based firms have committed over S$5 billion since 2024	Manufacturing, data centres, logistics, regional operations

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Economic Development Board (EDB) as the lead agency for foreign investors, offering facilitation, site selection and incentive packages for manufacturing, headquarters, R&D and services projects
- Enterprise Singapore for trade, SME partnerships and market-access support, with Budget 2026 raising Market Readiness Assistance support to 70% until March 2029
- Monetary Authority of Singapore (MAS) licensing for banking, capital markets, payments and fund management, including the Variable Capital Company (VCC) fund structure

- Open capital account with no exchange controls; profits, dividends and capital can be repatriated freely and the Singapore dollar is managed against a trade-weighted basket
- Fast company incorporation through ACRA, an extensive double-taxation treaty network and an internationally recognised commercial court and arbitration ecosystem (SICC, SIAC)
- JTC Corporation industrial land and purpose-built estates (Jurong Island, Tuas, one-north, Seletar) for manufacturing, logistics and R&D investors
- Talent pathways through the Employment Pass, ONE Pass and Tech.Pass, noting updated Employment Pass and S Pass salary thresholds for new applicants from January 2027

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Singapore in October 2026 is delivering growth well above its long-run potential on the back of strong global demand for AI-related electronics. GDP grew 5.0% in 2025 and accelerated through 2026, rising 6.3% in Q1, 6.2% in Q2 and 5.4% in Q3 (advance estimate), led by manufacturing (+7.5%), construction (+8.8%) and trade-related services. The government raised its 2026 growth forecast to 4.5–5.5% in August, while MAS Core Inflation is projected at a moderate 1.5–2.0% for the year, allowing MAS to keep its exchange-rate policy unchanged in October. Foreign direct investment inflows reached about $151 billion in 2025 according to UNCTAD data, the largest in Southeast Asia, and EDB secured S$14.2 billion of fixed asset investment commitments, mostly in manufacturing. Budget 2026 reinforced this momentum with a national AI push, S$37 billion for research and innovation under RIE2030 and enhanced enterprise support.

As one of the world's most open economies, with annual trade of about S$2.5 trillion, Singapore's main structural consideration is its exposure to global trade policy and imported energy. Since 24 July 2026 the US has applied a 12.5% Section 301 tariff to about one-third of Singapore's US-bound exports, worth around S$9.5 billion, although semiconductors, pharmaceuticals, energy products and selected electronics and aerospace goods are exempt. The government is engaging Washington carefully while protecting Singapore's wider trade relationships, and the economy continues to grow strongly. Singapore's buffers are exceptional: official foreign reserves reached S$553.6 billion in September 2026, the highest since early 2022, and the budget remains in surplus. Its network of free trade agreements, its role as a regional hub and progress on low-carbon electricity imports create opportunities for investors in supply-chain diversification, energy transition and regional headquarters operations.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
US tariffs on part of Singapore's exports	A 12.5% US Section 301 tariff since July 2026 covers about S$9.5 billion of exports, including chemicals and optical goods, while semiconductors and pharmaceuticals are exempt	Review product-level exposure and use Singapore's wide FTA network to diversify markets; Enterprise Singapore offers enhanced internationalisation support
US-China technology competition and export controls	Singapore's role as a neutral trading hub means investors in semiconductors and AI hardware face strict export-control compliance expectations	Build robust export-control and end-user screening into operations; Singapore's reputation for rule-of-law enforcement supports trusted-hub positioning
Business costs and land constraints	Office, industrial land and labour costs are high by regional standards	Pair Singapore headquarters and high-value functions with lower-cost operations in the JS-SEZ or wider ASEAN; Budget 2026 provides a 40% corporate income tax rebate for YA 2026
Imported energy and price exposure	Singapore imports almost all of its energy, and Middle East tensions have pushed up energy prices in 2026	Factor energy efficiency into site design; the low-carbon electricity import programme is opening opportunities in regional renewables and grid links
Pace of low-carbon electricity imports	Industry analysis in October 2026 suggests imports may reach about half of the 2035 target share	Early movers can participate in approved import projects, including solar imports from Malaysia approved in 2026
Talent and foreign workforce policy	Tight labour markets and rising Employment Pass salary thresholds from 2027 increase hiring costs for foreign	Plan workforce mixes early, invest in local hiring and training, and use Budget 2026 enterprise and skills support

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	professionals	
Global minimum tax (Pillar Two)	Singapore's implementation of the 15% global minimum tax changes the value of traditional tax incentives for large multinationals	Work with EDB on newer incentives tied to substantive activity and seek early tax advice on group structures

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Singapore offers one of the lowest-risk investment environments in the world, combining political stability, strong rule of law, an open capital account and exceptional financial buffers, with official foreign reserves of S$553.6 billion and a fiscal surplus. Growth has been strong through 2026, supported by AI-related manufacturing, and inflation remains moderate. The main considerations are external: the 12.5% US tariff on part of Singapore's exports, US-China technology competition, elevated energy prices and high domestic costs. Each is manageable through product-level tariff review, robust export-control compliance, energy-efficient operations and a hub-and-spoke model that pairs Singapore with lower-cost regional locations such as the JS-SEZ. For most investors, Singapore's predictability and connectivity remain its defining advantages.

MARKET ACCESS

Singapore is a founding member of ASEAN and the ASEAN Economic Community, a WTO member, and a party to both the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) and the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPTPP). It also has bilateral free trade agreements with major partners including the US, the EU, the UK, China, Japan and India, as well as pioneering digital economy agreements. Its main export markets are in Asia, notably China, Malaysia, Hong Kong and Indonesia, together with the US and Europe. As a leading global transhipment and bunkering hub, and with Changi Airport connecting it across Asia and beyond, Singapore provides investors with unmatched access to the fast-growing ASEAN market and wider Asia.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Prime Minister's Office (Prime Minister and Finance Minister Lawrence Wong)	Sets national economic strategy, including the national AI push and Budget 2026 priorities	Primary reference point for Singapore's long-term economic direction
Economic Development Board (EDB)	Lead agency for attracting and anchoring foreign investment, incentives and headquarters activity	Standard first point of contact for any significant investment
Monetary Authority of Singapore (MAS)	Central bank and integrated financial regulator; manages exchange-rate-based monetary policy	Essential for financial-services licensing and fund structures
Ministry of Energy, Trade and Industry (formerly MTI)	Renamed in October 2026 to reflect its growing energy role; leads trade negotiations, including with the US on tariffs	Relevant for trade policy, tariff developments and energy-transition opportunities
Enterprise Singapore	Supports trade, SME development and international partnerships	Useful partner for joint ventures with local firms and regional expansion
JTC Corporation	Plans and develops industrial land and specialised estates	Key counterpart for manufacturing, logistics and R&D site requirements
Temasek and GIC	Major state investment companies with significant domestic and global portfolios	Potential co-investors and partners for large-scale projects

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Singapore Business Federation is the apex business chamber, alongside the British Chamber of Commerce Singapore, the American Chamber of Commerce in Singapore, the European Chamber of Commerce and other national chambers that provide practical market intelligence and advocacy. EDB and Enterprise Singapore run regular sector briefings and investor programmes, and joint investment forums with Malaysia support entry into the JS-SEZ. Major events such as Singapore FinTech Festival and Singapore International Energy Week offer efficient access to policymakers and partners. Singapore also hosts the regional headquarters of many development finance institutions, multilateral banks and global investors, making it a natural base for deal origination across Southeast Asia.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Singapore suits investors seeking a stable, well-regulated base for Asian operations: financial-services, asset and wealth managers using MAS licensing and VCC structures; technology, AI and semiconductor companies drawn by strong demand and government support; advanced manufacturing, biomedical and specialty chemicals investors; and maritime, aviation and logistics firms building on Singapore's hub status. It is also well suited to multinationals establishing regional headquarters, and to energy-transition investors targeting low-carbon fuels and electricity imports. Investors with cost-sensitive operations can combine a Singapore headquarters with production in the JS-SEZ or wider ASEAN.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage EDB early on project structure and incentives
Discuss the project scope, location and talent needs with EDB to secure facilitation and incentives that reflect Pillar Two rules.

STEP 2: Review tariff and export-control exposure
Assess which products fall under the 12.5% US tariff or its exemptions and build export-control compliance into supply-chain planning.

STEP 3: Design a hub-and-spoke regional model
Consider combining Singapore headquarters, finance and R&D functions with lower-cost operations in the JS-SEZ or wider ASEAN.

STEP 4: Use Singapore's legal and financial infrastructure
Structure contracts and funds through Singapore law, SIAC arbitration and MAS-regulated vehicles to maximise legal certainty.

STEP 5: Plan talent and workforce strategy ahead of 2027 changes
Map hiring needs against the updated Employment Pass and S Pass thresholds and use available training and enterprise support.